

and analyze them in advance. Make sure you look at houses that have recently sold, not those that are currently on the market.

- When you start looking at homes, consider location-related features like your commute time, the parking situation, the school district, and property taxes. Know where you stand on HOA communities and factor any HOA fees into your monthly budget.
- Once all these things are in order (and you've picked out your real estate agent and have been preapproved for a loan), you're as ready as you'll ever be. Keep your eyes open for a good deal, and don't hesitate when that deal pops up.